

Chapter 53-4

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The Japanese-style decorated private room remained silent for a long time.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi's gazes met, both discovering incredulous emotions in each other's eyes.

There was even a hint of eeriness and fear.

Because Zhao Ying had an appointment to play golf in the afternoon, Liang Shi wandered around alone after eating with her.

Later, finding herself unable to focus on shopping, she locked herself in her car, thinking about this problem while waiting for Xu Qingzhu.

She had thought about it all afternoon but couldn't figure it out.

It was probably because Mrs. Qi's oppressive presence was too strong, suppressing her entire train of thought. All the information points in her mind were like a tangled mess, and she couldn't find where the thread began.

Several times she felt she was about to find it, but to no avail.

When she met Xu Qingzhu in the evening, she was still not in the right state—she could even forget to pay when buying bubble tea.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu was following behind her, avoiding the embarrassment of being called back to pay in the crowd.

With some time before the concert started, the two decided to eat at a Japanese restaurant.

After entering the private room, Liang Shi meticulously recounted the entire process of encountering Mrs. Qi that morning.

There was no choice—it was too bizarre.

Her subjective emotions were too intense, causing her to lose objective thinking.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu immediately discovered the most important point, and when both spoke that word in unison, they both fell silent.

Why would Mrs. Qi say she had lost a daughter before?

After the silence, Xu Qingzhu drank some bubble tea, trying to apply logic to this matter. "I asked Zhao Xuning before, and she said Qi Jiao jumped off a building once during her third year of middle school¹, and afterwards she disappeared like she had vanished. So could she be referring to that incident? In her heart, Qi Jiao had died once."

But Liang Shi's thinking was completely opened up by that word "again."

After Xu Qingzhu proposed this possibility, she slowly shook her head. "It doesn't seem likely."

The afternoon's confusion seemed to find an outlet at this moment, and the tangled mess in her mind began to become clear.

After a long while, Liang Shi said gently, "When she was talking to me, she mentioned two different ways of addressing her—one was Qi Jiao, and the other was 'my Jiao Jiao.' When she called out 'my Jiao Jiao,' her tone was tender and lingering, as if she were missing someone who could never return."

"Right." Xu Qingzhu pulled the threads from her memory, also remembering the first time she met Mrs. Qi.

At that time, she had also said, "She looks so much like our Jiao Jiao."

Her tone was exactly as Liang Shi described—gentle, lingering, and tinged with nostalgia.

"But when she talked about Qi Jiao, she showed no emotion." Liang Shi said. "And I feel she has an extremely strong desire to control Qi Jiao. She knew I had gone to find Qi Jiao and warned me not to look for her again."

"What is she afraid we'll discover?" Xu Qingzhu asked in confusion.

Liang Shi shook her head. "That's unclear. Before..."

She suddenly stopped.

Just then, a server came in to serve a dish, and she remained deep in thought.

After the server left, Xu Qingzhu asked, "What happened?"

"When I went to find Qi Jiao last time, she said to me—'If I tell you, Qi Jiao has already...'" Liang Shi said. "She only said this half sentence, then stopped. What could follow that?"

"Gone crazy? Died? Been killed?" Xu Qingzhu frowned. "But isn't the current Qi Jiao the same person as before?"

"Not certain." Liang Shi said. "But from the photos, it's the same face."

"But I don't understand." Xu Qingzhu said. "If your mom—the one from the Liang family—if she wanted to abuse you, couldn't she do it herself? Why throw you to Yang Jiani?"

Liang Shi bit her lip with a bitter smile. "She probably still wanted to be a good mother in front of her children."

So she used someone else to do her dirty work².

She couldn't understand Qiu Zimin either.

In her view, Qiu Zimin's behavior was very much like that of a madwoman.

Madpeople couldn't be understood by ordinary people, and one should never try to enter a madperson's inner world or think from a madperson's perspective—doing so might turn you into the next madperson.

Liang Shi felt that many questions about Mrs. Qi still needed to be asked of Qi Jiao.

But she couldn't bear to pour salt on that gentle girl's wounds.

She had been so frightened at the film set today, let alone Qi Jiao who had been experiencing those things all along.

But if she didn't ask, would Qi Jiao be better off?

She really wanted to avenge her childhood.

All domestic violence should go to hell.

Because she was thinking about this matter, Liang Shi ate the entire meal absent-mindedly.

Xu Qingzhu also noticed something was wrong with her mood, so after finishing the meal, she proactively said, "Why don't we just go straight home? We can listen to the concert another time and go back to rest early."

Liang Shi panicked upon hearing this, immediately saying, "No need, I'm fine."

She still had to listen to the concert—she needed to complete her mission!

Moreover, the tickets were already bought.

She heard this was a world-class pianist, with tickets costing two thousand yuan each.

Liang Shi couldn't possibly waste four thousand yuan, even if she was preoccupied!

She answered too excitedly, startling even Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu asked in confusion, "Do you like her that much?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Well, not really.

This pianist didn't exist in Liang Shi's previous world, and Liang Shi's accomplishments in music were indeed not high—she often fell asleep listening to pure music.

It had the same effect as a poor student listening to English to fall asleep.

Facing Xu Qingzhu's question now, she coughed lightly. "It's alright."

So the two went to the concert hall.

1. **Third year of middle school:** In the Chinese education system, this refers to the final year of junior high school (around age 14-15), which is typically a high-stress period due to important entrance exams.
2. **Used someone else to do her dirty work:** The Chinese idiom "借刀殺人" literally means "borrow a knife to kill someone," referring to using another person as a tool to accomplish something harmful while keeping one's own hands clean.